

FORUM : Discussion Point.

JOHN OWEN & THOMAS GOODWIN

Only Quasi-Independents ?

Thomas Goodwin :

"As we acknowledge elective occasional Synods of the elders of many Churches, as the Churches have need to refer cases of difference to them ; so in case of maladministration, or an unjust proceeding in the sentence of excommunication, and the like, we acknowledge appeals or complaints may be made to other Churches ; and the elders of those Churches met in a Synod, who being offended, may as an ordinance of Christ, judge, and declare that sentence to be null, void, and unjust ; and that not simply as any company of men may so judge, giving their judgments of a fact done, but as an ordinance of Christ in such cases, and for that end sanctified by Him to judge and declare in matters of difference."

*Cited on p. 205 "The Government of the Kingdom of Christ"
by James Moir Porteus.*

John Owen

In 1689, some thirty years after the Savoy declaration, John Owen's treatise "The True Nature of a Gospel Church", was first published. According to the Prefatory Note, printed on page 2 of Volume 16 in the B.O.T. edition, which volume begins with this treatise, it is really necessary to read first the treatise Owen had printed in 1681, entitled "Inquiry concerning Evangelical Churches" (printed in Vol.15), then to follow on with this, in order to gain a proper and comprehensive appreciation of Owen's doctrine of Church structures and government. But the editor here also draws attention to an anecdote about how the dying Owen is supposed to have said to a Mr. George Redpath that "he had seen his mistake as to the Independent way" and that now (a day or two before Owen's death) Owen had said that "after his utmost search into the Scriptures and antiquity, he was now satisfied that Presbytery was the way Christ had appointed in his New Testament Church." This anecdote is given little credence by Goold, the 19th century editor of Owen's Works, since he points out that (a), a full reading of the two treatises together establishes Owen to be indubitably an Independent, and (b), that Owen corrected, for his publisher, this treatise, immediately before his death, something unthinkable, he claims, if Owen had undergone so radical a change in his views, "he was not the man to quit the world in a spirit of dishonourable reticence, but would frankly have avowed to what extent his previous convictions had been modified or abandoned". But this is a simplistic view, if anything, which requires in order

to accept Goold's position that one set of evidence, that of Redpath, be dismissed out of hand. This is totally unsatisfactory, and careful rumination concerning the two disparate sets of evidence yields the result that *both* testimonies can be true, and that this is arguably supported by certain statements in the second of Owen's treatises, where, if anything, he manifests an observable *vaccillation* and *ambivalence*, if not outright *self-contradiction* in these matters. This would then accommodate both sets of evidence harmoniously. The man was but human, after all, and he was in his dying days.

Accordingly, we provide herewith certain extracts from Owen's treatise on "The True Nature of a Gospel Church", with reference to Owen's views on Synods. The reader is asked to study them carefully, with a view to noting any internal contradictions or ambivalence. All references are to Owen's Works, Vol. 16 in the B.O.T. reprint edition of 1968. Though still evidently clinging, to some extent at least, to the Savoy Declaration, there are certain "give-aways" evident, and even contrary propositions. Words in bold type indicate our emphasis :

(1.) "This communion (between individual Churches) is **incumbent on every Church** with respect unto **all** other Churches of Christ in the world equally. (p. 183)

(2.) "Wherefore such a communion of Churches is to be enquired after as from which **no** true Church of Christ is or can be excluded". (p. 185).

(3.) "The communion of churches is *their joint actings in the same gospel duties towards God in Christ, with their mutual actings towards each other with respect unto the end of their institution and being, which is the glory of Christ in the edification of the whole catholic (not R.C.) church.*" (p.191).

(4.) "Churches have communion unto their mutual edification by **advice in Synods or Councils** Synods are the meetings of diverse churches by their messengers or delegates, to **consult** and **determine** of such things as are of common concernment unto them all by virtue of this communion which is exercised in them." (p.195)

(5.) This *acting in Synods* is an **institution of Jesus Christ**.....fortified with apostolic example; for having erected such a church-state (!), and disposed all His churches into such order and mutual relation unto one another as that none of them can be complete or discharge their whole duty without mutual **advice and counsel**, He hath thereby **ordained** this way of their communion in Synods, no other being possible unto that end. (p.196).

(6.) “Synods are consecrated unto the use of the Churches in **all ages**, by the example of the apostles in their guidance of the first churches of Jews and Gentiles, which hath the force of a *divine institution* as being **given under the infallible conduct of the Holy Ghost**” (Acts 15). (p. 197).

(7.) “Considering what we have learned in these later ages, by woeful experience, it were not amiss if those churches who do walk in express communion would *frequently meet in synods*, to enquire into the spiritual state of them all, and to **give advice** for the correction of what is amiss....” (p. 199).

(8.) “Hence it is evident what are the ends of such synods.....

- (i) to prevent divisions from differences in judgment & practice
 - (ii) to avoid or cure offences
 - (iii) to advance the gospel by **Joint Confession** and agreement in the faith.
 - (iv) to give concurrent testimony against pernicious heresies or errors
 - (v) to relieve such by **advice** as may be by any Diotrophes unduly cast out
- (Summary from p. 199).

(9.) “There is a threefold power ascribed unto synods....

- (i) **Declarative** consisting in an authoritative teaching and declaring the mind of God in the Scripture
- (ii) **Constitutive appointing and ordaining** (!) things to be believed, or done and observed, by and upon its own authority (! !)
- (iii) **Executive** in acts of Jurisdiction towards persons and churches (p.205)

(10.) “The power of a synod for the **execution** of its **decrees** respects

- (i) The things or doctrines declared, and is **recommendatory** of them,
- (ii) Persons, to **censure, excommunicate, or punish**...(! ! !) (p.206)

(11.) “The authority of a synod declaring the mind of God from the Scripture in doctrine, or giving counsel as unto practice synodically, unto them whose proper representatives are present in it, whose **decrees** and **determinations** are to be **received** and **submitted unto** on the evidence of their truth and necessity, as **recommended** by authority of the synod” (p.206)

(12.) “Hence it will follow that a synod convened in the name of Christ..... may **declare** and **determine** the mind of the Holy Ghost in the Scripture and **decree** the observation of (such)which are to be **received, owned** and **observed** on the evidence of the mind of the Holy Ghost in them, and on the **ministerial authority of the synod itself**” (last para. p.208).

Enough ! Owen in paragraphs 1, 2, and 3, may be still within the confines of Puritan Independency, but certainly not **all** of today's Independency !

The fact is that in taking the steps Owen outlines in these three initial paragraphs, one has already made a giant leap away from the fundamental ideal of Independency. But Owen is still in line with Savoy here, though it must be said that many modern Independents are not, and are locked in an "our little chapel down the road" mentality, to the exclusion of the rest of God's churches district-wide, let alone nation-wide or world-wide!

In paragraphs 4 and 5, note how Owen is clinging on to the idea of Synods delivering just **advice** and **counsel**. But note how he asserts in 4 that mutual inter-church communion is to be **via** the Synod, and in 5 he asserts that Synods are **God-ordained**.

Then, by paragraph 6, while reasserting the God-ordained basis of Synods, he asserts also how they are to be regarded as **instituted for all ages**, and then in paragraph 7 he **recommends frequent Synodical gatherings**, this latter being a definite move away from Savoy's "occasional Synods", which are "not" even "instituted by Christ". (Savoy Article XXVII. See page 16 herein). Still, Owen only allows such synods to "**give advice**".

Paragraph 8 expands Owen's ideas on the purposes of Synods. An excellent adumbration it is, but vitiated at the end by that word **advice** again. But one wonders how the purposes listed (i) to (v) could ever be effectuated just by advice.

In paragraph 9, Owen is really talking Presbyterianism! He has come a long, long way from Savoy at this juncture, using words like "Constitutive appointing and ordaining" and "**executive (!) acts of Jurisdiction** towards persons and churches".

In paragraph 10 Owen talks in Westminster style of "the power of a synod for the **execution** of its **decrees**", and to "censure, excommunicate and **punish**" (!). In fact, at this point, Owen sounds more Westminster than Westminster does! (Check article III of Westminster Ch. 31, herein on page 16). But yet, in the middle of all this, Owen has "recommendatory". I ask, how can one have the "execution" of "decrees" which are only "recommendatory"?

Paragraph 11 betrays the same ambivalence. "**Decrees and determinations** are to be **received** and **submitted** to as recommended by authority of the synod" How can one only "recommend" obedience to a "decree"?

And as to paragraph 12, Owen's last words on this subject, one can only say: "Spoken like a true Presbyterian, Sir!"

I ask, did Owen veer away from the Independent position in his last days? Can one accept Redpath's evidence as being an indication, possibly over-stated, that Owen's views were *in process of shifting* strongly in a Presbyterian direction, and that this explains both the ambivalence in his final treatise, and the fact that he did not, as Goold says he would have, make a radical break when checking the printers proofs? **We open this forum for readers to write in to give their considered views**, which we hope to publish, in Forum Response in Issue 12.